

Primary Source Reading 1: Practicing Death

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Phaedo, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 9a: Philosophy as Preparation for Death

Before you read: On the day of his execution, Socrates's friends gather in his cell expecting grief. Instead they find him arguing that the philosopher should not fear death at all. Before he can defend that claim, he needs to say what death actually is. As you read, notice how precisely he defines it, and what follows from that definition about how a philosopher ought to have been living all along.

What Is Death?

SOCRATES: Do we believe that there is such a thing as death?

SIMMIAS: To be sure.

SOCRATES: Is it not the separation of soul and body? And to be dead is the completion of this; when the soul exists in herself, and is released from the body and the body is released from the soul, what is this but death?

SIMMIAS: Just so. (64c)

SOCRATES: Would you not say that [the philosopher] is entirely concerned with the soul and not with the body? He would like, as far as he can, to get away from the body and to turn to the soul.

SIMMIAS: Quite true. (64e–65a)

The Body as Obstacle

SOCRATES: For the body is a source of endless trouble to us by reason of the mere requirement of food; and is liable also to diseases which overtake and impede us in the search after true being: it fills us full of loves, and lusts, and fears, and fancies of all kinds, and endless foolery, and in fact, as men say, takes away from us the power of thinking at all. Whence come wars, and fightings, and factions? whence but from the body and the lusts of the body? ... It has been proved to us by experience that if we would have pure knowledge of anything we must be quit of the body — the soul in herself must behold things in themselves: and then we shall attain the wisdom which we desire, and of which we say that we are lovers, not while we live, but after death. (66b–d)

Purification Defined

SOCRATES: And what is purification but the separation of the soul from the body, as I was saying before; the habit of the soul gathering and collecting herself into herself

from all sides out of the body; the dwelling in her own place alone, as in another life, so also in this, as far as she can — the release of the soul from the chains of the body?

SIMMIAS: Very true.

SOCRATES: And this separation and release of the soul from the body is termed death?

SIMMIAS: To be sure.

SOCRATES: And the true philosophers, and they only, are ever seeking to release the soul. Is not the separation and release of the soul from the body their especial study?

SIMMIAS: That is true.

SOCRATES: And, as I was saying at first, there would be a ridiculous contradiction in men studying to live as nearly as they can in a state of death, and yet repining when it comes upon them. (67c–e)

After you read: Socrates has now built the argument the whole lesson rests on: if death is the soul's separation from the body, and if philosophy is the practice of separating the soul from the body's distractions in order to think clearly, then the philosopher has been rehearsing death all along. Notice that Socrates does not say suicide is justified — only that fear is not. Keep this distinction in mind as you read the lesson's account of why the philosopher waits for death without dreading it.